



free will
and
determinism

against
compatibilist
free will

A large red circle with a slight drop shadow, containing white text. The text is arranged in three lines, centered within the circle.

**against
incompatibilist
free will**

1. No one has any choice about events which happened in the distant past.
 2. No one has any choice about DINOSAUR.
(1)
 3. If determinism is true, then only one future is consistent with the state of the world at a time + the laws of nature.
 4. If determinism is true, then the laws of nature say that if DINOSAUR happens, then DECISION happens. (3)
 5. No one has any choice about what the laws of nature are.
 6. If determinism is true, then no one has any choice about the fact that if DINOSAUR then DECISION. (4,5)
 7. If no one has about choice about whether P, and no one has any choice about whether, if P, then Q, then no one has any choice about whether Q.
-

C. If determinism is true, then no one has any choice about DECISION. (2,6,7)

This argument seems to show that the combination of four theses — that No one has any choice about the past, no choice about the laws of nature, the no choice principle, and determinism — rules out free will.

Since the first three of these theses seem quite plausible, the argument seems to show that if determinism is true, there are no free actions — and hence that free will is incompatible with determinism.

The consequence argument

1. Free will is incompatible with determinism.
 2. If Libertarianism is true, then there is no free will.
-

C. There is no free will.

The master argument against the reality of free will

Real/|the master argument:

The consequence argument is a defense of premise (1). If you believe in free will, and find the consequence argument persuasive, it looks tempting to reply to the master argument by denying premise (2).

But, we'll see now, this argument can also be given a plausible defense.

One way to introduce this defense is with the following quote from

David Hume:

Hume's basic thought is that there is a big difference between free actions and actions which are random or chance.

Here's a thought experiment:

Now ask yourself: is Alex's choice free? It seems very clear that it is not. It is undetermined by facts prior to the relevant run of the Randomizer, but it is random. It is not up to Alex what he does; and free actions have to be up to the person doing the action.

This suggests:

But now consider the idea that free will requires the falsity of determinism. If this is true, then it must be that free actions (or their immediate causes) are undetermined:

But consider what an undetermined act would be. It would be an action which is such that the entire history of the universe up to that point is consistent with the act either happening or not happening. So if the act happens, nothing **makes** it happen. In particular, nothing that the person who does the action, or anyone else, does makes the action happen.

If an action is undetermined, then the agent does not control whether it happens.

So it is not up to anyone whether the action happens. But this suggests:

If an act is
free, then the
agent must
control
whether it
happens.

If Libertarianism is true,
then, if there are free
actions, those actions are
undetermined by anything
prior to the action.



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2. None has any choice about DIDS. ATJR.

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6. If $\det A$ is true, then A has any

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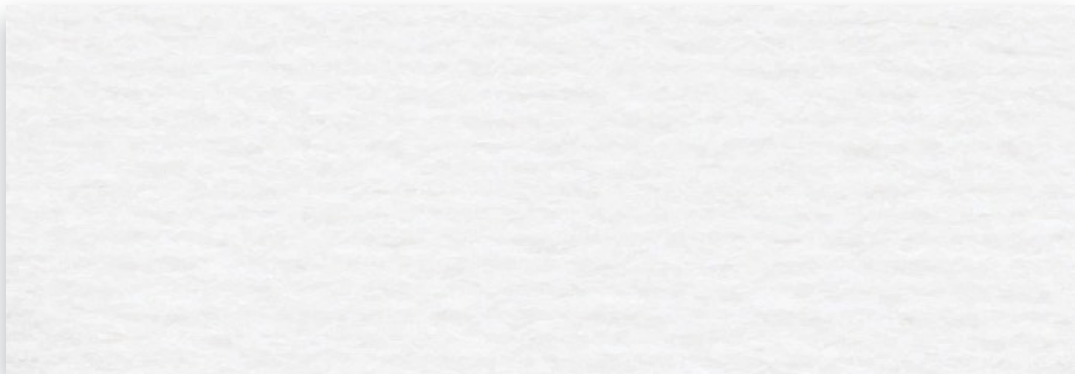
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activities; those activities are

believe in free will rejects premise (2).

Compatibility believers in free will reject premise (1). An incompatibilist

for (2), and one for (3).

or premise (3) is true. We're now going to look at two arguments — one

Now, so far we have been given no reason to think that either premise (2)

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The master argument against the reality of free will



The consequence argument



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